

UNDER THE British Raj

COLONIAL INDIA

In 1857–1858, the people of India rose up against the rule of the British East India Company in what was known as the “Mutiny” or India’s First War of Independence. Although the Mutiny failed to win back the subcontinent, it ended Company rule, and sparked the dawn of the “Raj”—an era of direct rule by the British government.

During Company rule, life for the British in India had been culturally and racially mixed. Company employees were encouraged, in the absence of British women, to marry high-class Indian women. Known as *begums*, these were often Muslims from courtly families whose Anglo-Indian children then went on to be reared and educated in Britain. About 90 percent of British men in India had Indian wives by the mid-18th century. This practice had reduced greatly by the 19th century, but it was still common to keep a *bibi*, or mistress. One army colonel even agreed to circumcision so that a Muslim woman would become his mistress.

The Mutiny and the forging of the empire sharpened racial divisions. In the uprising, British women had been attacked and killed,

and this was used to bolster ideas of white superiority. The “native rapist” was juxtaposed with the white man—the gallant protector of the pure, white woman. By the second-half of the 19th century, relations between British men and Indian women had practically ceased, existing only between lower-class British men and Indian prostitutes or servants. Eurasians, the offspring of Anglo-Indian liaisons, were perceived as a threat to white superiority. British interactions with Indians in general were much less, too, and the British began to create a “home away from home” on Indian soil. They built towns at high elevations—creating greater physical distance between themselves and the

► Agency on the stage

In India, the performing arts gave women, especially those from lower classes and castes (the Indian social hierarchy), the opportunity to shine in a career, perhaps more than any other profession of that era.



**“YOU HAVE NEVER
GIVEN A WOMAN THE
CHANCE TO MAKE
HER VOICE STRONG!”**

PANDITA RAMABAI, ANNUAL CONGRESS MEETING, DECEMBER 1889

